

## Chapter Seventeen

### The Lie That Looked Like Mercy

For one week, safe enough worked.

Not perfectly.

Never perfectly.

But enough.

Nora did not jump.

Maya visited her father and told Nora what she chose to tell. Sometimes it was medical, sometimes absurd. Tomas had declared war on hospital pudding. Lucia had begun carrying three kinds of crackers because “one cannot trust vending machines in times of crisis.” Maya had cried twice in bathrooms and once in an elevator, and she told Nora because Nora had promised not to make every tear an emergency.

Adam slept more.

Not enough, but more.

He stopped pretending his tiredness was a small inconvenience. Once, when Nora asked how he was, he answered, “Angry and hungry,” then looked startled by his own honesty. Nora made pasta. It was overcooked. He ate two bowls and did not fix anything for almost an entire evening.

Nora wrote in the document called BORDERS every day.

Sometimes one sentence.

Sometimes pages.

She wrote:

I am allowed to feel afraid.

I am not allowed to make fear the judge.

She wrote:

If someone gives me truth, receive it. Do not grab for more.

She wrote:

Love is not surveillance.

Then, one night, after a long phone call with Maya in which Maya had said, “I don’t want to talk about Dad tonight. Tell me something stupid,” Nora wrote:

Maybe trust is not believing nothing will hurt me.  
Maybe trust is believing I can survive not knowing everything.

She stared at that sentence for a long time.

Then she closed the laptop and cried quietly, not because she was breaking, but because something in her was trying very hard to grow.

On Friday afternoon, Maya invited Nora and Adam to dinner.

Not hospital dinner.

Real dinner.

At her apartment.

“I need to cook something that was not made by a machine or a tired cafeteria employee,” Maya said on the phone. “Also, Dad says if I eat one more packaged sandwich, he will haunt me preemptively.”

Nora was folding laundry. “Can someone haunt preemptively?”

“My father can.”

“Fair.”

“Come at seven. Adam too.”

Nora paused.

Maya heard it. “What?”

“Nothing.”

“Nora.”

“I’m just checking with myself.”

“That sounds suspiciously healthy.”

“It feels annoying.”

Maya laughed. “Good. Be annoyed and come hungry.”

After they hung up, Nora stood with a towel in her hands and waited for the old story to assemble.

Maya inviting both of them.

Maya and Adam in the same room.

Maya and Adam sharing a week of hospital texts Nora had not read.

Nothing came.

Not nothing exactly. A flicker. A small sting. But not the old flood.

Nora breathed through it.

Then she texted Adam.

Maya invited us for dinner at seven.

Adam replied:

Good. I’ll bring dessert.

Nora smiled.

Then he sent another message.

And no pears.

She laughed aloud.

At seven, Maya’s apartment smelled of garlic, tomatoes, and something slightly burned.

Nora arrived with flowers. Adam arrived two minutes later with a bakery box and the cautious expression of a man unsure whether dessert counted as useful support.

Maya opened the door wearing an apron over her sweater and flour on one cheek.

“You are both late.”

Nora looked at Adam. “He is two minutes late.”

Adam lifted the box. “I brought cake.”

Maya narrowed her eyes. “That reduces your sentence.”

Nora held out the flowers. “I brought these.”

Maya took them, her expression softening. “Thank you.”

Then she looked at the bouquet more closely.

“Are these from my shop?”

“Yes.”

“You bought flowers from my workplace to bring to my house?”

“I support local business.”

“You support emotional absurdity.”

Adam stepped inside. “Both are important sectors.”

Maya pointed at him. “Do not encourage her.”

The evening began well.

That was what made Nora trust it too much.

They ate at Maya’s small table by the window, where rain tapped lightly against the glass and the city blurred into gold below. The pasta was too spicy. The bread was perfect. Adam’s cake had raspberries on top, which Maya ate first while insisting she was “checking for poison.”

They talked about Tomas.

But not only Tomas.

They talked about Luis's mysterious girlfriend, whom Nora's mother had already decided was either "too quiet" or "not quiet enough," despite not meeting her yet. They talked about Daniel's boys and their obsession with dinosaurs. Nora did not mention the separation. It felt good to hold that border.

They talked about Claire, carefully. Adam said he had seen her sister helping move boxes from 4B. Nora listened, felt the ache, and did not ask for more.

They talked about nothing.

For a while, nothing was the most beautiful subject in the world.

After dinner, Maya washed dishes despite Adam's protests.

"You brought cake," she told him. "You have done your civic duty."

Nora dried plates beside her.

Adam sat at the table with a cup of tea, looking around the apartment in that quiet way of his. Not assessing. Not searching. Just being somewhere without needing to improve it.

Maya leaned close to Nora and whispered, "He looks less haunted."

"He slept."

"Miracles continue."

"I heard that," Adam said.

"You were meant to," Maya replied.

The apartment filled with gentle laughter.

Then Maya's phone rang.

The sound cut through the room.

Maya looked at the screen.

Her whole face changed.

Nora saw it.

Adam saw it.

Maya picked up quickly. “Mom?”

Silence.

The room held still.

Maya turned away from them, one hand braced on the counter.

“What do you mean?”

Nora’s fingers tightened around the dish towel.

Adam stood.

Maya listened.

Her shoulders rose.

Then dropped.

“I’m coming,” she said. “No, I’m coming now.”

She ended the call.

For half a second, no one spoke.

Then Maya said, “Dad has a fever. They’re checking for infection.”

Adam moved first. “I’ll drive.”

Maya nodded immediately.

Nora put down the towel. “I’ll come too.”

Maya turned.

The look on her face stopped Nora before any words did.

Not rejection.

Calculation.

Painful, frightened calculation.

Nora felt the old wound open.

Maya was deciding whether Nora was safe enough.

“I can wait,” Nora said quickly.

Maya closed her eyes. “Nora—”

“No. It’s okay. I can wait here. Or go home. Whatever helps.”

Adam looked between them.

Maya pressed her fingers to her forehead. “I don’t know what helps.”

The honesty was almost worse.

Nora stepped back.

“Then go,” she said. “Both of you. I’ll clean up.”

Maya looked at her with visible guilt.

Do not make her carry you while she is carrying him.

Tomas’s voice returned.

Nora forced herself to smile.

It probably looked terrible.

“Go,” she said again.

Maya crossed the room and grabbed her coat.

Adam took his keys from the table.

At the door, Maya stopped and turned back. “I’ll text you.”

“Only when you can.”

Maya nodded.

Then she hesitated.

Nora saw the hesitation.

The desire to comfort her.

The impossibility of it.

Nora lifted one hand. “Go.”

Maya left.

Adam lingered one second longer.

His eyes met Nora’s.

“I’ll update you if Maya says it’s okay.”

The if hurt.

The fact that he said it mattered.

Nora nodded.

Then he was gone too.

The door closed.

The apartment, which had been warm and full minutes ago, went suddenly hollow.

Nora stood in Maya’s kitchen with a damp dish towel in one hand and the sound of rain against the window.

This was right.

Maya’s father was sick. Maya needed to go. Adam could drive. Nora had not been invited. Nora could wait.

This was mature.

This was respectful.

This was agony.

She turned back to the sink.



Washed a plate.

Dried it.

Washed another.

Her hands moved with careful obedience.

The old story began anyway.

Maya in Adam's car again.

Not like before. Worse now because there was real fear, real urgency. Adam driving fast but controlled. Maya crying quietly. Adam reaching over. Maya taking his hand.

Nora shut her eyes.

Stop.

She opened them and washed a glass.

Her phone remained silent.

Five minutes.

Ten.

Twenty.

She cleaned the counter. Put leftovers into containers. Found the right cabinet after opening three wrong ones. Folded the dish towel over the oven handle.

The apartment still smelled of garlic and cake.

Her phone buzzed.

Nora grabbed it.

Maya.

At hospital. Waiting for doctor. Fever is high but they're treating it. I'm scared.

Nora's throat tightened.

She typed:

I'm here. No need to answer. I love you.

Maya replied with a heart.

Then nothing.

Nora sat at the table.

The bakery box was still there, one slice of cake left inside. Three forks on three plates. Proof that the evening had been real before fear entered and rearranged it.

A pressure touched the back of Nora's eyes.

She went still.

"No," she whispered.

The pressure faded.

Then returned.

Not strong.

Not sudden.

Tempting.

That was the worst part.

It did not feel like being dragged.

It felt like being offered a window.

Hospital light. Maya's fear. Adam nearby. A truth Nora could know if she stopped resisting.

Nora gripped the edge of the table.

Do not search people.

Do not confuse pain with permission.

But Maya had said she was scared.

Was fear an invitation?

No.

No.

Nora stood and walked to the window.

The city blurred beneath rain. Across the street, apartments glowed. Lives framed in rectangles of light. A man cooking. A woman holding a baby. Someone closing curtains. Rooms she could see only from outside.

Her fear liked windows.

She stepped away.

Her phone buzzed again.

Adam.

Maya says I can tell you: doctors think infection, antibiotics started. She's with Lucia. I'm in the hallway.

Nora read the message.

Then read it again.

He was in the hallway.

Not with Maya.

Relief came.

Then shame.

Then another thought, quiet and poisonous:

Why did he specify that?

Because he knew she would wonder.

Because he knew she needed reassurance.

Because her fear had taught him to speak like a man giving evidence.

Nora sat down on the floor.

The pressure behind her eyes swelled.

She covered them with both hands.

“No.”

This time, the word shook.

The apartment stretched.

The rain grew louder.

Not violent.

Insistent.

A door opening, slowly, as if giving her time to consent to the violation.

That was new.

Worse.

Nora could feel the direction of it.

Not Maya.

Not Adam.

Hospital.

Lucia.

Maya’s mother.

A woman trying not to fall apart beside her husband’s bed.

Nora gasped.

The pull strengthened.

She could know.

She could know if Tomas was worse than they were saying.

She could know if Maya needed her.

She could know what everyone was protecting her from.

Nora pressed her forehead to the floor.

“No.”

The pull held.

She crawled toward the table and grabbed her phone.

Her hands shook so badly she nearly dropped it.

She called Adam.

He answered on the first ring. “Nora?”

“Talk to me.”

His voice sharpened. “Pressure?”

“Yes.”

“Where are you?”

“Maya’s floor.”

“Sit down.”

“I am sitting. I need you to talk.”

“Okay. I’m here.”

“I think it’s Lucia.”

Adam went quiet.

“The pull,” Nora said. “I think it’s to Maya’s mother.”

He inhaled. “Do you know why?”

“Because I want to know what’s happening.”

The confession came out broken.

“I want to know if they’re hiding something. I want to know if it’s worse. I want to know if Maya is protecting me again.”

Adam’s voice was low. “Thank you for saying that.”

“Don’t thank me yet. It’s still pulling.”

“Then stay with my voice.”

“I’m trying.”

“You are in Maya’s apartment,” Adam said. “You are sitting on the floor. There is cake on the table. It has raspberries because Maya eats fruit off desserts like a raccoon.”

A laugh tore out of Nora, half sob.

“Keep going.”

“You are wearing your green sweater.”

“No, blue.”

“Sorry. Blue sweater. You are holding your phone too tightly because you always do that when you’re scared.”

The pressure trembled.

“You are not in Lucia’s body,” Adam said. “You are not in the hospital. You are not responsible for knowing everything before it hurts.”

Nora cried silently.

“You are Nora Reyes,” he continued. “You are in your own body. You are allowed to wait.”

Allowed.

The word struck something deep.

Waiting had felt like abandonment.

Like helplessness.

Like failure.

Adam made it sound like a right.

The pressure weakened.

Nora kept her forehead against her knees.

“I hate waiting.”

“I know.”

“It feels like being punished for not invading.”

Adam was quiet for a moment.

Then he said, “Maybe tonight waiting is how you protect Maya.”

The pressure thinned.

Nora breathed.

Once.

Twice.

The door closed.

Not slammed.

Closed.

Nora stayed on the floor, shaking.

“I’m here,” she whispered.

Adam exhaled shakily. “I know.”

“No. I mean I’m here.”

“I know,” he said again, and this time his voice broke.

They stayed on the phone until Maya texted again.

Fever coming down a little. Dad is awake and complaining, which is good.

Nora read it aloud to Adam, though he had received it too.

“Complaining is good,” he said.

“With Tomas, yes.”

Nora leaned back against the cabinet.

Her whole body ached.

But she had not jumped.

Not because there was no door.

Because she had chosen not to enter.

An hour later, Maya and Adam returned.

Nora had fallen asleep sitting against the cabinet, phone still in her hand. She woke to the sound of keys and Maya’s voice whispering her name.

“Nora?”

Nora opened her eyes.

Maya stood in the doorway, pale and exhausted, coat still wet from rain. Adam stood behind her, equally tired.

For a second, no one moved.

Then Maya crossed the kitchen and dropped to her knees in front of Nora.

“Adam told me,” she said.

Nora blinked slowly, still half asleep. “What?”

“That you felt the pull. That you called him. That you stayed.”

Nora looked past Maya to Adam.

He gave a small, apologetic shrug. “She asked why I looked like I had aged six years.”

Maya took Nora’s face in both hands.

Her palms were cold.



“You stayed,” Maya said.

Nora’s throat tightened.

“I wanted to know.”

“I know.”

“I almost—”

“But you didn’t.”

Maya’s eyes filled.

“My mother was a mess,” she whispered. “If you had gone into her tonight, Nora, I don’t know what that would have done to you.”

Nora closed her eyes.

A new horror moved through her.

Not for herself only.

For Lucia.

For the private terror of a wife beside a hospital bed.

“I’m sorry I wanted to.”

Maya shook her head. “Wanting is not taking.”

The sentence entered Nora like grace.

Adam sat on the floor beside them, back against the cabinet, too tired to pretend chairs mattered.

Maya leaned against Nora.

Nora leaned against Adam.

The three of them sat on the kitchen floor surrounded by dirty dishes, leftover cake, and the evidence of an evening interrupted by fear.

No one spoke for a while.

Then Maya said, “Dad asked for the pear.”

Nora opened one eye.

“What?”

“At the hospital. He was feverish and deeply irritating. He said, ‘Where is the disrespectful girl with the terrible fruit?’”

Adam smiled tiredly.

Nora laughed.

It came out watery but real.

Maya laughed too, then Adam, and for a few seconds the kitchen floor held something almost like joy.

Small.

Exhausted.

Ridiculous.

But joy.

Later, after Maya fell asleep on the couch and Adam made tea no one drank, Nora stood at the window again.

The rain had stopped.

Across the street, curtains were drawn over every apartment.

No windows.

No stories.

Only dark glass.

Adam came to stand beside her.

“You did something hard tonight,” he said.

“I did nothing.”

“No,” he said. “You waited.”

Nora looked at the dark windows.

Waiting still hurt.

But it no longer felt empty.

Maybe waiting was not the absence of love.

Maybe it was love refusing to become theft.

She leaned her head against Adam's shoulder.

No pressure came.

Behind them, Maya slept.

At the hospital, Tomas complained and lived through the night.

Somewhere in the city, Lucia rested beside him, her private fear still private.

And Nora let the room remain closed.